THE SUPREME INTERVENTION

The incident soon seeped into the national discourse, with #tirupati-laddoo trending on social media and right-wing Hindutva organisations raising the bogey of faith being under attack yet again. Most importantly, it set off a chain reaction among many of the big temples across India. From the new Ram temple in Ayodhya to the Bankey Bihari temple in Vrindavan to the Jagannath shrine in Puri to Trimbakeshwar in Nashik, samples of the temple prasad were being sent to labs to test their ingredients.

It was left to the Supreme Court to bring a modicum of sanity into the proceedings. On September 30, responding to a volley of petitions, the apex court took Naidu to task, telling him categorically to keep the "gods away from politics". It also chastised him for making statements without proof and asked why he went public with the animal fat allegations when the state police's special investigation team (SIT) probe ordered by his government was still pending.

The bench of Justices B.R. Gavai and K.V. Viswanathan said that "when the investigation is under process, it was not appropriate on the part of a high constitutional functionary [Naidu] to go public and make a statement which can affect the sentiments of crores of people across the world". The court also raised concerns about the impression being created that adulterated ghee was used to make the laddoos, when it was clear that the test results from July—which formed the basis for Naidu's comments—were from already rejected consignments of ghee.

A NEW PURIFICATION MOVEMENT

Animal fat has been a sensitive issue in India historically—just the rumour of cartridges being greased with lard (pork fat) and tallow (bovine fat) was enough to spark off a mutiny of the Indian sepoys in 1857. Striking a note of caution, political commentator K. Nageshwar says: "While the political aspects are important, we must also address the systemic failure at play. This issue goes beyond politics and impacts society as a whole. This isn't just a case of adulteration like, say, in the hotel industry... it involves religious sensitivities and if people believe it, the consequences could lead to severe unrest."

Naidu alleging 'animal fat' adulteration in the Tirupati laddoo is part of a wider trend across the country to put a religious imprimatur on objects and places in the name of ensuring their purity. At the Trimbakeshwar temple near Nashik, home to one of the 12 hallowed jyotirlinga Shiva shrines in the country, a Hindu group has started issuing 'Aum certificates' to those selling religious material outside the temple (see *Ringing the Division Bell*). Implicit in it is the insinuation that Muslim sellers of such puja items deliberately defile them. Though secular forces have raised objections, the Aum Pratisthan's project continues apace



SIGN HERE File photo of ex-CM Jagan Reddy visiting the Tirumala temple

AS THE TIRUPATI LADDOO CONTROVERSY EXPLODED, TEMPLES ACROSS INDIA RUSHED TO SEND THE SACRED OFFERINGS AT THEIR ESTABLISHMENTS FOR TESTS OF PURITY